Robert Kennedy had successfully delivered the “additional message” to Dobrynin with which he had been entrusted by his brother. But that was not the end of his mission: its sine qua non was to assure the secrecy of the deal. He told Dobrynin: “The president can’t say anything public in this regard about Turkey.” According to Dobrynin, Robert added that John Kennedy’s “comments about Turkey are extremely confidential; besides him and his brother, only 2–3 people know about it in Washington.” Kennedy could not swear Dobrynin and, through him, Khrushchev to secrecy, but he indicated very clearly that the deal would be honored only if it remained secret. Robert Kennedy requested an answer from Khrushchev by the following day: a “clear answer in principle, not to get into a wordy discussion, which might drag things out. The current serious situation, unfortunately, is such that there is very little time to resolve this whole issue.”

Robert Kennedy bade goodbye to Dobrynin, leaving him the number of a direct telephone line to the White House through which he was asked to deliver Khrushchev’s response as soon as he got it. Kennedy also told the ambassador that he was going to see his brother, with whom he was spending “almost all his time now.” Dobrynin fully understood the seriousness of the situation as communicated not only by the content of Robert’s message but also by his overall appearance and demeanor. “I should say that during our meeting R. Kennedy was very upset,” reads the final paragraph of Dobrynin’s report to Moscow, “in any case, I’ve never seen him like this before. True, about twice he tried to return to the topic of ‘deception’ (that he talked about so persistently during our previous meeting), but he did so in passing and without any edge to it. He didn’t even try to get into fights on various subjects, as he usually does, and only persistently returned to one topic: time is of the essence and we shouldn’t miss the chance.”[15]

The concluding portion of the conversation is known to us only through Dobrynin’s recollections as recorded in the report he filed that night and the memoirs he wrote decades later. Robert Kennedy’s recollections are of little use. Both in the report to Rusk that he filed three days later, on October 30, when the most acute phase of the crisis was already over, and in *Thirteen Days*, which he cowrote years later, he remained silent about the Turkish